What We've Been Taught to See – A Collection

with poems by Jesse Parent, Danez Smith and Crystal Valentine

White Jesus

(with a pronounced European accent) Hey, everybody!

It's-a me – White Jesus!

I've come to break baguettes

and share some cab sav with some

of my favorite sinners!

You guys!

I know what you're thinking,

"Hey, White Jesus, what's with that crazy accent?"

Well, just like the rest of White Jesus, it's vaguely

European and depends on your frame of reference.

After all, God may have created us all in His image

but White Jesus gets created in the image

of those who are trying to make a sale!

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INTRODUCTION

Through satire, reclamation, and sharp critique, these poems challenge the long-standing portrayal of a white Jesus, exposing how faith has been shaped by power, culture, and control.

What begins as humor quickly turns into a reckoning. Layers of history, like the Shroud of Turin, are peeled back to reveal a figure rooted not in European imagery, but in a brown body born of an oppressed people.

This is a collection about identity, distortion, and the consequences of rewriting religious history. It asks us to reconsider what we've been taught to see . . . and what it has cost us not to question it.

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I mean, who doesn't have a nice painting

of White Jesus in their homes?

Or a nice little sculpture

of yours truly with some lambs,

or maybe me as a baby in a manger

with White Mary and White Joseph

and White Angels and White Shepherds

and some vaguely non-white Wise Men?

I mean they had to travel a long way

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into the lands of Caucasia to bring me all
these smelly gifts.

White Jesus just works better as a present
when he looks like the rest of the family.
Didn't your Grandmother say she
tracked your genealogy back to the
House of David?
Just like White Jesus, lineage is important!
Watch as I get nailed to your family tree
and you wash me white, root and stem,
and slake my thirst with a sponge
soaked in vinegar wine
to sour my history.
Trade my sandals for Birkenstocks,
my coiled hair for long auburn locks,
my rough linen for white sheets,
I mean, who doesn't love wearing white sheets?

Just like your family tree
I'm a self portrait
of poor white Renaissance guys
who can only afford a mirror for a model.

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Can you imagine how great it has to feel
to get a whole religion to worship your image?
Carve all my sculptures from marble or alabaster,
Make me as White as Sushi Burrito or
Great Harvest flatbread.

Let anyone who doesn't look like White Jesus know
that no matter how Christ-like they live their lives
they will never look like salvation.
Tell them about the blackness of their souls.
How much can that weigh someone down?
Gesture at all the stained glass and tell
them how beautiful the light looks coming
through my creamy complexion.
Twist up any Bible verse you need to justify my
supremacy.
Tell them the Mark of Cain is their dark skin color.
Show them all the paintings of white Adam and Eve
as proof of your flesh's primacy.
I am the Exodus from Egypt.
This is what Palestine probably looks like, right?
No refugee ever looked like me.

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Keep citing the fact of scripture and the evidence of

illustrations.

Now look at-a me, again!

White Jesus!

Doesn't my accent seem so much less crazy

in comparison to the rest of me?

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jesse Parent
Online Transcript:
https://artistsofutah.org/15Bytes/sunday-blog-read-jesse-parent/
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Black Jesus Writes a Letter to White Jesus

Hi, you might not know who I am, but my name is Jesus.

Jesus Christ of Nazareth

of Mary

of God

Son of God

Born in a brown wooden manger.

Born with my mother's eyes --

My mother's ***brown*** eyes

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with skin of bronze (that means brown)

with hair of wool (that means nappy)

My name is Jesus.

Jesus, whose Father begat the world

Whose mother begat him

Without the seed of an Earthly man

Whose father planted the last seed of Eden inside a girl

Who hadn't been entered yet

Like a temple whose husband

Hadn't cried out for God in there yet.

Yeah, ***that*** Jesus!

How you is?

See I've heard a rumor . . .

I've heard you've been walking around bearing my cross.

I've seen the pictures

eyes blue as a man that dies and stays dead

skin white as his bone once the flesh cascades off

hair – long, blonde and straight

as the people that pierce spear and nail into the light of

this world . . . ***Me***

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What kind of martyr are you?

I ***died*** for this planet.

You died for a chance to plaster the face of Europe

(the land that destroyed it) on the body that saved it.

My blood did not run so it could be bleached away.

I'm the stain of Heaven on everyone's soul.

God's son -- Water Runner -- Healer

Much realer than you could ever be.

The scapegoat.

The original black sheep.

Most popular Lynch victim of all time

My color is no coincidence . . .

I had to be black to save you all from your own darkness.

When I rose up, it was never meant for anybody to lie in my place.

So you tell me . . .

When you saw the rock moved,

Did you wait at the mouth of the cave for the painter to show up?

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Did you find all the pictures of me and smear them with glue?

When your people conquered the world in my father's name (without asking),

Did you cover me in the hide of some dead King

to hide the ugly secret of your savior

underneath the flesh of the one that you really worship?

Jesus, if we can call you that,

I'm simply asking you to rub the white out

off all those pictures of you.

Show them the me underneath all that.

Show them that the world was born and reborn in the body of the darkest continent.

Show them that salvation don't always come.

In the light, correct yourself or be your own Messiah.

Pass on, then tell your cold flesh to resurrect

Then you can walk in my soul.

I did not die so that you could die

--Me (Black Jesus)

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Danez Smith
Chap Book: hands on ya knees
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The Artists' Quarter 408 St. Peter Street, St. Paul, MN 55102; Jan 2012

Transcript can be found online at
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=0kPYg6oufgQ

And the News Reporter says "Jesus is White"

She says it with a smile
Like it's the most obvious thing in the world

So sure of herself

Of her privilege

Her ability to change history

Rewrite bodies to make them look like her

She says it the same way politicians say racism no longer exists

The same way police officers call dead Black boys thugs

The same way white gentrifiers call Brooklyn home

She says it with an American accent

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Her voice doing that American thing

Crawling out of her throat

Reaching to clasp onto something

That does not belong to her

I laugh to myself

What makes a Black man a Black man?

Is it a white woman's confirmation?

Is it her head nod?

Is it the way she's allowed to go on national television

And auto correct the Bible and God himself,

Tell him who his son really was?

What makes a black man a black man:

The way reporters retell their deaths like fairytales

The way their skulls split across pavement

The way they cannot outrun a bullet

The way they cannot inherit privilege

How can she say Jesus was a white man

when he died the blackest way possible?

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With his hands up

With his mother watching,

Crying at his feet

Her tears nothing more than gossip

for the news reporters or prophets to document

With his body left to sour in the sun

With his human stripped from his Black

Remember that?

How the whole world was saved by a Black man

By a man so loved by God,

He called him kin

He called him Black

Now ain't that suspicious?

Ain't that news worthy?

Ain't that something worth being killed over?

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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